

Tune In

World Cup Fever puts Agent 001 in dire need of a TV Tuner card

The Cricket World Cup is on and that means other modes of entertainment such as playing games, downloading music and tweaking my BIOS would have to take the back seat for a while. But the TV was already being put to use—tearing my family and the other animals from Bush's ramblings was going to be quite a task. But the PC was mine, all mine and all I needed was the right TV Tuner card, a big tub of buttered popcorn and a boisterous bunch of patriotic friends.

Adding TV to your computer is as simple as switching channels when you have Windows 98. I needed to add cable from my TV outlet to the PC and use an adapter to connect the TV Tuner card output to my speaker's input line. The TV cable wasn't long enough and I made a mental note to get a longer cable when I

called upon my friends at Lamington Road.

With a faint idea of the various flavours available, I set out—matching my cash inputs with a good quality card was the name of the game. I could opt for a TV-only solution in the form of an add-on PCI TV Tuner card, or one with a decent 3D Display Card with an extra goodie.

At my first stop, the dealer showed me an 'excellent' AGP card with a TV Tuner onboard—the ATi All-in-Wonder Radeon 9700 with 128 MB of DDR memory—for only Rs 38,000. The AIW 9700 Pro is just about everybody's dream card. You get top-of-the-line 3D and 2D performance, digital video capture, TV Out and PVR capabilities. The AIW comes with output connectors that include S-Video, 1/8-inch stereo audio and an RCA S/PDIF digital audio jack for Dolby Digital audio streams to an external decoder. Audio is now routed to the soundcard through the internal input port. It comes bundled with an extensive software suite (that would save me loads of money if I were to buy it separately) that includes Pinnacle Studio 8.4 SE for video capture, Matchware Mediator 7 to create presentations dripping with rich audio, video, sounds and text, and ATi's own Multimedia Center, which has PVR capabilities, players for virtually everything (Video CDs, CDs and DVDs) and a media cataloguing library.

I mentally calculated how much my kidney would fetch me and considered the left eye too. Better sense prevailed and I decided to save the body parts for the next time I upgraded my processor.

His next best choice was a slightly sober ASUS GeForce2 MX AGP card with an onboard TV Tuner for Rs 8,900. I shook my head and casually sauntered out of the shop.

The next guy was more in touch with reality and the annual income of a technology snoop—he offered me a PixelView TV PCI Tuner card for Rs 2,200 and an Addcom PCI TV Tuner for Rs 2,300. However, I was determined to survey all possibilities before I chose the right one.

The next in line tantalised me with a

Pinnacle PCTV Plus TV Tuner that cost Rs 2,800. Looking around the shop for a while, I asked if I could get any decent VGA+TV solution—out came the Compro VideoMate Cinema. This package comprised a GeForce4 MX AGP graphics card with 64 MB of blazing DDR memory and a Personal Cinema Box—the TV kit and a remote control. The GeForce4

MX is no comparison to the ATi Radeon 9700 AGP card, but saved me a body part by costing

Rs 11,925. It was a step above my existing SiS 6326 AGP card with a meager 8 MB RAM. The whole solution offered pretty good 3D graphics, along with an external TV Tuner Box. The TV Box also offered a nifty video capture facility and video output. A slick black remote control in the box was a very cool add-on.

The shopkeeper eagerly explained the various features of the card, Time Shift being the most impressive among them. This feature allows you to watch a previously recorded program, while recording the current live telecast in MPG format. Considering the size of AVI files generated while recording, this is an excellent feature for those with budget hard drives.

Weighing all the pros and cons carefully, I decided to buy the Compro VideoMate Cinema solution costing Rs 11,995. It gave me a good 3D card and brought the World Cup to my PC. It did turn out to be slightly steeper than what I had bargained for, but the combination package price made the deal seem worthy. I could finally play all 3D games on a bigger screen area such as my 21-inch TV, and watch and record TV programs. Content with the proceedings, I left with my pocket lighter but my heart soaring. Time to watch the World Cup! ■

ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar



■ A TV Tuner card comes in two varieties—a stand-alone PCI 'daughter card' or as a full-fledged AGP video card.

■ If you already have an AGP video card, then you need to purchase a PCI daughter card. This daughter card should also be a consideration if budget is of importance.

■ External plug-and-play TV Tuner boxes are also available that connect to the PC's Universal Serial Bus (USB) port, though these cards lack some of the features of the internal cards.

■ Select a TV Tuner card with a frequency rate equal to or greater than your monitor. Most new monitors are compatible with 75 to 85 Hz TV Tuners.

■ Choose a model with a remote control for greater comfort.

■ If you intend on using your TV Tuner card as a Personal Video Recorder (PVR) solution, ensure that you have adequate storage space.